

How Businesses Can Reduce Administrative Delays

Most companies don't know it, but their administrative silos are slowly draining far more time and money than they realise. A missing signature or approval can back up a project; a manual process that should have been automated long ago can frustrate customers and frustrate your staff by giving them repetitive work without providing any benefit to the business. The good news is that most delays are fixable if you know where to look!

Identify Where the Bottlenecks Actually Are

Before you can start repairing anything, it's important to first develop a map of where you're actually losing time. Many businesses believe they already have identified the slowest processes. However, more often than not, they overlook other hidden bottlenecks caused by in-process steps that are not being questioned, such as redundant data entry or an approval that has been sitting in someone else's email for days. By taking the time to track the amount of time taken at every stage of a process (even informally) for a week or two, you will likely discover some very surprising trend patterns.

Standardize and Document Processes

The delays caused by unequal handling of processes will often be a large factor in wasted time and effort. Since everyone is completing the same task differently than another person, error rates will go up, and therefore also will the solution time, as it will take more effort to fix all errors made by the different ways they were done. By using clear, written standard operating procedures, we can allow for consistency in how we complete our job functions, in addition to providing guidelines for our new hires, thus reducing any need for back-and-forth when dealing with employees until their understanding is established.

Automate Repetitive Tasks

Automating the manual data entry, repetitive approvals, and document-processing workflows is the most promising application for automation. Accounts payable solutions, scheduling applications, document-management systems, and basic approval-processing applications can save many hours of time spent on administrative tasks weekly. Even simple automation solutions, such as automatically routing a form to the right department or sending a notification that reminds users to complete a task, will help reduce the chance for the task to sit on someone's desk doing nothing.

Reduce Approval Layers

While multiple levels of approvals may sometimes be needed for establishing accountability, having too many layers of approvals can cause a slowdown in the process. Reviewing who really needs to approve/get involved with decisions, and removing those unnecessary levels, will allow for faster turnaround times. In most cases, having one accountable person involved for each step in the process is sufficient to establish sufficient accountability.

Centralize Information and Documents

If workers have to search through email, shared drives, and obsolete spreadsheets to find the material they need, delays are certain. A centralised document approval/communication system will allow workers to use one source of truth, reducing the amount of time spent having to look for or request information that is supposed to be available.

Invest in Staff Training

Many administrative delays are the result of employees being unaware of how to properly use existing systems. By regularly training staff on how to utilise internal tools and processes, they will not waste time developing workarounds and will not need to ask their colleagues for assistance to accomplish a task that they should be able to accomplish without any assistance.

Monitor and Adjust Regularly

The process for reducing administrative delays is ongoing, as your company will continue to improve with growth by identifying areas that create more bottlenecks, i.e., giving employees opportunities to provide feedback on inconveniences experienced in their daily routine helps improve your overall process by having you evaluate and hopefully adjust processes in a timely manner so everything continues functioning properly for you well into the future.

Final Thoughts

Small inefficiencies in multiple departments and processes create administrative delays, not just one big issue. Companies who take the time to find their friction points, standardize workflows, and automate when appropriate generally experience improvements in speed, accuracy, and job satisfaction.